

The Missing Chapter

“You’re going to do *what?*” Kira’s voice was harsh—harsher than Elyssa had heard in a long time.

“Aya needs someone with magic to activate the portal for her mission, and I don’t trust anyone else to do it. So I’m going with her.”

“I get *that*, you idiot. The question is, *why aren’t you bringing me?*” Kira’s anger at being excluded baffled Elyssa.

“Well, I... didn’t think we needed anyone else.” Kira knelt down next to her wife.

“I swear, for as smart as you are, you are so *oblivious* sometimes.” She paused momentarily as she locked eyes with Elyssa. “It’s not about what I contribute to the mission. Even if it weren’t our little girl going out there, I’d still be going. I have lived for 232 years, most of them without you, and with all we’ve been through recently?” She leaned in and kissed her wife. “I am *never* going to leave you again. Especially not something as dangerous as this. Where you go, I go—and I’m going to do whatever I can to help. That’s final.”

Elyssa took her wife’s hand. As scared as she was to go on this one last mission to save the galaxy, she felt just a bit better now, knowing that Kira would be with her.

Approaching the planet was terrifying. Elyssa’s artillerist cannon, the only one she could make these days, had been no help with trying to intercept enemy fire and protect the ship so far. Kira had left the deck once the fighting started to help Lyania pilot, which seemed to be working well though. Lyania was a talented pilot, and Kira’s expertise in spelljammers and Clockwork Horror behaviors was a huge boon.

None of that mattered once the laser locked onto their ship, though.

There wasn’t as tangible a notice as one would have thought—no clear sign the targeting crystal had selected a target. Maybe there was, and it was just easy to miss it in the heat of combat. What keyed Elyssa in, though, was the sound of the crystal wiring and the alien shell in the Starwasp whining, like it was resonating. The coloration of them both shifted slightly, aligning with the colors of the laser’s targeting crystal. They’d locked on to the ship through the Weave—the next laser would be guided directly into the ship with no chance of missing.

That was when a miracle had happened. Nylos, Aya’s friend who’d manned the cannon, fired a shot with perfect timing. The cannonball intercepted the energy, evaporating into nothingness at the center of the laser—but not before it tore through the attack, leaving a hole wide enough to pilot a spelljammer through. Lyania narrowly made it into the opening, and the targeting crystal ceased resonating against their ship. They were safe... for now.

As the Starwasp pulled into range, Aya, Nylos, Miji, and Dave rushed onto the deck to be portaled out. Aya gave her mom a quick hug before pulling away. Aya didn’t have the words to say anything, but she gestured—the sign for “I love you.” One of the first signs Elyssa had taught her family. Elyssa

signed it back, a tear in her eye. Someone else was saying something—she thought it was Nylos, saying something about how they were going to win. Truthfully, though, she wasn't paying attention. The sight of her little girl jumping through the portal was all she could focus on.

The plan had been simple in theory. Dart in as fast as possible using the Starwasp, portal the strike force onto the planet, and then escape back to the Starcutter, which was acting as a flagship in the back.

The plan hadn't accounted for the fact that the Clockwork Horrors could—and *would*—weaponize gravity and the Weave itself. Ships had been yanked towards the planet, and escape was more difficult than anticipated. Add in the attacking ships and planetary defense systems, and... well, their escape was taking forever. Elyssa had attempted to man the ship's cannon, which bore one of her infusions to aid in its usability, but she wasn't very good with it. Eventually, she gave up and began heading inside while the Starwasp continued dodging explosions and lasers.

That was when she heard it. The high-pitched whine of crystallized magic, resonating in tandem with something shaking it on the same line of magic.

The targeting crystals had locked onto their ship, and this time, they had no miracle on board.

As Elyssa hopped into the piloting room of the Starwasp, she clutched her wife's hand before pulling her into the tightest hug she could. The two of them looked over at Lyania, piloting on the helm as she had back when Aya first started her journey. She gave them a brief string of hand signs:

I guess this is the end, huh? Even if it wasn't for long, thank you both for being my crew.

The Starwasp was enveloped in a blinding white light.